



I AM BIG. IT'S THE PICTURES THAT GOT SMALL

SUNSET BOULEVARD / 1950

IN CONTEXT

GENRE

Drama

DIRECTOR

Billy Wilder

WRITERS

**Charles Brackett,
Billy Wilder**

STARS

Gloria Swanson, William Holden, Erich von Stroheim, Nancy Olson

BEFORE

1928 Gloria Swanson's silent movie career peaks with *Sadie Thompson*, a drama set in the South Pacific.

1944 *Double Indemnity* is Billy Wilder's classic film noir about the double dealings at an LA insurance company.

AFTER

1959 Wilder shows his versatility with *Some Like It Hot*, a comedy in which Tony Curtis and Jack Lemmon dress in drag to escape the mob.

At one point in Billy Wilder's *Sunset Boulevard*, faded silent-movie star Norma Desmond (Gloria Swanson) flashes a look at the audience. "We didn't need dialogue. We had faces!" she says, as her eyes shine with madness, sorrow, and fear. Norma's cracked state of mind, and her fall from sanity and fame, can all be seen in that single close-up.

Sunset Boulevard is a blackly comic elegy to Hollywood's silent age, and the movie is filled with faces from those glory days, including Buster Keaton, looking time ravaged at a card table, and legendary director Cecil B. DeMille, both playing themselves in wry, self-deprecating cameos. Norma's servant Max is played by Erich von Stroheim, another famous director of the

Joe dresses in white tie and tails for Norma's New Year's Eve party, only to find that she has invited no other guests and is trying to woo him.

